

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 292

Culture (OWC): [Mbuti \(FO04\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Central Africa

Field Date: 1951, 1957, 1958

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Not Specified

Section Title(S): THE VILLAGE CONTEXT

In the Mbuti Villager situation the relationship appears to be symmetrical and permissive, though both sides do occasionally take offense, the village side even sometimes taking counteraction. The ineffectiveness of taking offense or action, however, only serves to heighten the characteristic "social disjunction," and there is no doubt that beneath the display of hostility and disrespect there is cooperation, and even considerable amity. Considering the completely opposed value systems of the two worlds, this is, indeed, the only way in which the two peoples could meet and still retain a separate identity. The reasons for the meeting taking place at all, as we have already seen are circumstantial--the historical invasion of the forest by the villagers and their use of the Mbuti as guides; the continued parasitism of the Mbuti upon the villagers long after the original need for cooperation had gone; the contemporary mutual convenience of economic exchange; sheer territorial propinquity. These reasons do not lead automatically or easily to a structured relationship, particularly when the values of the two peoples are so divergent, so while a form of **joking** relationship helps to stabilize the alliance, maintaining the combination of Radcliffe-Brown's "conjunctive and disjunctive components," it is not by itself enough.

121
[Theoretical
 Orientation](#)

177
[Acculturation And
 Culture Contact](#)

571
[Social Relationships
 And Groups](#)

We have seen the methods by which the villagers have sought to further stabilize the situation, through a formal economic-exchange system, a fictive parallel-kinship system, and through introduction to village supernatural sanctions by establishment of magico-religious bonds through *karé* blood brotherhood and *nkumbi* initiation. Any one of these had it worked, would have reduced the Mbuti to subordination, yet this plainly has not been done. The defense of the Mbuti has lain in their own indigenous forest system, which works not only to maintain internal cohesion but also to maintain the utmost possible structural distance from the village world while allowing a minimal amount of "mutually convenient" economic exchange.

177
[Acculturation And
 Culture Contact](#)

439
[External Trade](#)

563
[Ethnic Stratification](#)

608
[Artificial Kin
 Relationships](#)

621

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)